

Key NPCs: Allies, Handlers, and Threats

In *Zero Sum*, NPCs are defined by their leverage, their resources, and their breaking point. No one is fearless.

The Fixers & Handlers

- **The Architect (The Information Broker):** Operates out of an antique bookstore in Berlin. He communicates entirely offline via one-time pads. He has access to zero-day exploits and leaked databases, but his prices are exorbitant, and he will sell the players out if a major intelligence agency corners him.
- **Sarah Chen (The Burned Lawyer):** A former corporate litigator who found out too much about a sovereign wealth fund. She now operates from the shadows, providing players with legal loopholes, forged documents, and emergency safehouses.

The Antagonists

- **“The Auditor” (Corporate Cleaner):** Not an assassin in the traditional sense. The Auditor is a forensic accountant who dismantles a target’s life. They freeze bank accounts, trigger IRS audits, falsify credit records, and ensure the target is evicted and unemployable before the physical threats even begin.
- **Director Marcus Thorne (Private Intelligence):** Head of a Private Military Company’s domestic surveillance wing. He views the world strictly in terms of acceptable losses and return on investment. He employs psychological warfare and precise, deniable violence.

The “Wildcards”

- **Katarina (The Zero-Day Merchant):** A 22-year-old prodigy living off the grid in Eastern Europe. She buys and sells software vulnerabilities. She doesn’t care about politics or morals, only cryptocurrency and leverage.

- **Agent Miller (The Ambitious Federal Agent):** An FBI or MI5 agent who genuinely believes they are doing the right thing. They are hunting the players because the players have been framed by a higher power. Miller is dangerous because they are righteous and resourceful.